

AMERICAN LITERATURE

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Syllabus - D - Detailed, ND - Not Detailed

Imp - Lessons in red are studied in each unit.

Unit-I

Edgar Allan Poe - Dream Land, The Raven ND

Walt Whitman - When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom D

Emily Dickinson - Success is Counted Sweetest, Hope is the thing with feathers, I felt a funeral in my brain, ~~My~~ Great Pain a Formal Feeling Comes All D

Unit-II

Robert Frost - Stopping by the Woods, Birches, Reparatment All D

Wallace Stevens - The Emperor of Ice-Cream, Sunday Morning ND

Sylvia Plath - Daddy, Lady Lazarus, The Bee Meeting ND

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Unit-III

O'Neil - Emperor Jones D

Tennessee Williams - The Glass Menagerie ND

~~Arthur Miller~~ - Death of a Salesman ND

Unit-IV

Emerson - Self Reliance D

Thoreau - Civil Disobedience ND

Ellison - Invisible Man ND

Unit-V

Hawthorne - The Scarlet Letter ND

Faulkner - Sound and the Fury ND

Hemingway - The Old Man and the Sea ND

Unit-1

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Emily Dickinson - Success is Counted Sweetest, Hope is the thing with feathers, I felt a funeral in my brain, After Great pain a Formal Feeling Comes All D

About the writer -

Emily Dickinson (1830-1886)

Era & Age - American Renaissance,
American Romantic Period
(1820-1865)

Titles - Great American Lyric poet

Admiration - Modernist poets, Feminist
critics

Critics - Critics disliked her unusual
punctuation and style.

Contribution -

- Developed unique poetic techniques
- Explored death, faith and identity.
- Influenced modern poetry profoundly.

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1. Success is Counted Sweetest -

Central Message - Understanding value arises
from absence and deprivation.

Poetic form - Hymn, Quatrain

Themes - Death, Desire, Disappointment, Failure,
war

Emotions - Empathy, Hopelessness, Pain, Sadness

Full Lyric poem -

Success is Counted Sweetest
By those who never Succeed.
To comprehend a nectar
Requires sorest need.

Not one for all the purple Host
Who took the flag today
Can tell the definition
So clear of Victory

As he defeated-dying-
On whose forbidden ear
The distant strains of triumph
Burst agonized and clear!

Summary -

Rather than praising achievement, this poem values through absence, showing how distance and loss shape a sharper, more honest understanding of what success truly means.

People who never succeed appreciate success more deeply, just as someone in desperate need truly appreciates and comprehends the value of nectar.

The battlefield metaphor - victorious soldiers cannot define victory as clearly as a dying soldier who hears the distant celebration of triumph.

This dramatic contrast emphasizes that profound understanding comes through deprivation and suffering, not achievement.

The poem builds to its powerful conclusion with the dying soldier heightened perception - hearing the "distant strains of triumph" with agonizing clarity precisely because he cannot participate in them.

Poetic and Stylistic Techniques - Paradox,

Extended Metaphor, Contrast, Alliteration

Resonance and Sound Patterning, Imagery, Diction, Enjambment, Irony, Symbolism

2. "Hope" is the thing with feathers -

Central Message - Hope lives in everyone and is fragile

Poetic form - Quatrain

Themes - Healing, Journey, Nature, Recovery, Spirituality

Emotions - Contentment, Faith, Gratitude, Hope, Optimism

Full Lyric poem -

"Hope" is the thing with feathers -
That perches in the Soul -
And sings the tune without the words -
And never stops - at all -

And sweetest - in the Gale - is heard -
And some must be the Storm -
That could abash the little Bird
That kept so many warm -

I've heard it in the coldest land -
And on the strangest Sea -

Yet - never - in Extremity,
It asked a Gumb - Ag me.

Summary -

This poem skillfully describes a feeling that should be indescribable - hope. "Hope" is a metaphorically transformed into a strong - wild bird that lives within the human soul and sings its song no matter what.

This poem breathes life into an abstract concept. The speaker defines "Hope" as a feathered creature that dwells inside the human spirit. This feathery thing sings a wordless tune, not stopping under any circumstances.

Its tune sounds best when heard in fierce winds. Only an incredibly severe storm could stop this bird from singing. The bird has made many people feel warm.

The speaker has heard the bird's singing in the coldest places, and on the weirdest seas. But in the speaker's experiences, even in the most extreme ones, the bird has never asked for

anything in return.

Poetic and Stylistic techniques - Anaphora,

Extended metaphor, Personification, Symbolism, Imagery, Alliteration, Hyperbole

3. I felt a Funeral, in my Brain -

Central Message - Understanding other people's interior lives is difficult.

Speakers - Someone on verge of mental collapse

Poetic form - Ballad, Quatrain

Themes - Death, Identity, Journey, Madness

Emotions - Anxiety, Confusion, Depression, Grief

Full Lyric poem -

I felt a Funeral, in my Brain,
And Mourners to and fro
Kept treading - treading - till it seemed
That Sense was breaking through -

And when they all were seated,

A Service, like a Drum-
Kept beating-beating - till I thought
My Mind was going numb-

And then I heard them lift a Box
And Creak across my Soul.
With those same Boots of Lead, again,
Then Space - began to toll,

As all the Heavens were a Bell,
And Being, but an Ear,
And I, and Silence, some Strange Race
Wrecked, Solitary, here -

And then a Plank in Reason, broke,
And I dropped down, and down -
And hit a world, at every plunge,
And Finished knowing - then -

Summary -

This poem speaks on life, mental illness, and one person's collapsing sanity. The speaker feels as though a funeral service is taking place within his or her own mind. It feels like the funeral attendees are pacing back and forth inside the speaker's head.

The mourners finally take their seats

near the funeral service. yet this Service
doesn't contain any words. Instead, the
speaker can only make out a repetitive
drum like noise. This noise overwhelms
the speaker, causing the speaker's mind
to go blank, as it numb

Now the Service ends and the funeral
procession begins. The mourners lift a
casket and carry it as they walk
across the speaker's soul, which creaks
like an old wooden floor.

Even the sky (and possibly Heaven itself)
rings like a bell. The speaker is alone
in own body and mind, as it shipwrecked
there.

Finally, one of metaphorical glassboards
in the speaker's rational mind does break,
creating a hole through which the speaker
falls further and further down. While
falling the speaker seems to collide
with entire worlds, until the speaker's
mind shuts down altogether. Just as the
speaker is about to say what comes
after this state, the poem ends.

Poetic and Stylistic techniques - Extended
Metaphor,

Repetition, Personification, Onomatopoeia,
Alliteration, Imagery, Symbolism,
Enjambment, Slant Rhyme

4. After Great Pain, a Formal Feeling Comes -

Central Message - Deep pain leaves people emotionally numb and disconnected.

Speaker - A grieving observer

Poetic form - Couplets, Free Verse,
Quatrain, Quintain

Themes - Grief, Death, Healing, Recovery,
Spirituality

Emotions - Confusion, Grief, Hopelessness,
Pain, Sadness

1 stanza Full Lyric Poem -

1. After great pain, a formal feeling comes -
2. The Nerves sit ceremonious, like Tombs -
3. The Stupid Heart questions 'Was it He,
that bore,
4. And 'Yesterday, or Centuries before'?

1. The feet, mechanical, go round -
2. A wooden way
3. On ground, or dirt, or ought -
4. Regardless grown,
5. A Quartz contentment, like a stone -
1. This is the Hour of Lead -
2. Remembered, is outlived,
3. As freezing persons, recollect the Snow -
4. First - Chill - then Stupor - then the
letting go -

Summary -

The poem examines the aftermath of extreme pain, showing how grief becomes controlled, quiet and physical, revealing a mind struggling to survive through numbness rather than expression.

After intense emotional trauma, people feel stiff and solemn. Their senses are numb almost as though they are attending a funeral, or are graves themselves.

Speaker describes the dissociation and numbness that comes with loss. One enters into a period of "formal feeling" which is actually an absence of feeling. The next lines use various part of body to

Show how the cold as lobs spreads everywhere. The poet are woods and mechanical and move on autopilot. One lives like a stone does, cold and without any progress. Time passes, but one does not move.

It concludes with the Speaker describes the process of formal feelings as similar to that of death. One feels the chill, then the "stupor" and then the "letting go" happens and one dies.

Poetic and Stylistic techniques - Caesura, Alliteration, Consonance, Metaphor, Simile, Personification, Imagery, Paradox

Robert Frost - Stopping by the woods, Birches, Departmental All D

About the Writer -

Robert Frost (1874-1963)

Era & Age - Modern Age, Modern period (1900-1945)

Titles - Poet of New England

Admiration - General readers, Modern poets

Critics - Themes overly rural

Contribution -

- Blended traditional forms with modern ideas.
- Used nature as philosophical symbolism.
- Made American poetry Accessible.

1. Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening -

Central Message - One must remain committed to their responsibilities in the face of temptation.

Speaker - A traveler in the woods

Poetic Form -

Quatrain (Rubaiyat Stanza)

Themes - Death, Journey, Nature

Emotions - Bravery, Confidence, Compulsion

Full Poem -

Whose woods these are I think I know.
His house is in village though;
He will not see me stopping here
To watch his woods fill up with snow.

My little horse must think it queer
To stop without a farmhouse near
Between the woods and frozen lake
The darkest evening of the year.

He gives his harness bells a shake
To ask if there is some mistake.
The only other sound's the sweep
Of easy wind and downy flake.

The woods are lovely, dark and deep,
But I have promises to keep,
And miles to go before I sleep,
And miles to go before I sleep.

Summary -

This is a beautiful and introspective poem that explores themes of temptation, responsibility, and the allure of death, leaving the reader with a sense of peaceful contemplation.

The speaker thinks about who owns the wood that he is passing through and is fairly sure of knowing the landowner. However, the owner's home is far away in the village, and thus he is physically incapable of seeing the speaker pause to watch the snow fall in the forest.

The speaker thinks his horse must find it strange to stop so far from any signs of civilization. Indeed, they are surrounded only by the forest and a frozen lake, on the longest night of the year.

The horse shakes the bells on its harness, as if asking if the speaker has made a mistake by stopping. The only other sound besides the ringing of this bells is that of the wind and falling snowflakes, which the speaker likens to the feathers of goose down.

The speaker finds the woods very alluring, drawn both to their vastness and how dark and all encompassing they seem. However, the speaker has obligations to fulfill elsewhere. Thus, though he or she would like to stay and rest, the speaker knows there are many more miles to go before that will be possible.

Poetic and Stylistic techniques - Alliteration, Consonance, Assonance, Metaphor, Anaphora

Symbols - Woods - Mystery, beauty, temptation, and possibly death or escape from life

Snow - Silence, purity, Peace, Stillness or death

Darkness - The unknown, loneliness or death

The horse - Practicality, Common sense

Journey - Life journey and responsibilities

Sleep - Literally rest, but symbolically death

2. Birches -

Central Message - Balance nature and imagination with reality

Speaker - Adult reflecting on Youth

Poetic form - Blank Verse

Themes - Coming of age, Dreams, Identity, Journey, Nature

Emotions - Contentment, Freedom, Frustration, Hope, Joyfulness

Summary -

This poem is gentle yet thoughtful look at how the natural world and human experience come together. The poem shows how simple things like trees can bring both comfort and deep thinking, using nature as a way to talk about life's challenges and dreams.

The speaker begins by observing birch trees bent across a forest as straighter, darker trees, preferring to imagine they have been shaped by a boy's playful swinging rather than harsh ice storms.